VOLUME 1 — NID DAT EXAM GUIDE (B.Des / Integrated Pathway, Cycle 2027-28)

Contents

1. The exam in one page
2. Stage-by-stage walkthrough
3. Eligibility, reservation and documents
4. Marking and evaluation: what examiners reward
5. The complete NID DAT syllabus (inferred)
6. What previous NID papers teach us (previous-paper analysis and pattern evolution)
7. Topic frequency and priority table
8. Exam-day strategy and time management
9. How to use this package

1. The exam in one page

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APPLY (10 Sep – 30 Nov 2026, online)
        │
        ▼
DAT PRELIMS  ── Sun 20 Dec 2026 · 3 hrs · 100 marks · pen & paper · no negative marking
        │        (Handbook: 22 objective + 4 subjective; 2026 actual: 6 subjective Qs)
        │        → SHORTLISTING ONLY, score not carried forward
        ▼
DAT MAINS (Apr–May 2027, expected)
   ├── Studio Sensitivity Test  (hands-on: sketch, model, material)   ~60%
   └── In-Person Sensitivity Test (interaction / interview)            ~40%
        │
        ▼
FINAL MERIT (Mains only) → seat allotment by campus / discipline preference
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Labels: dates and the "not carried forward" rule are [OFFICIAL]; the 60/40 split and the 2026 paper shape are [REPORTED].

2. Stage-by-stage walkthrough

2.1 Application

- Apply online at admissions.nid.edu. You need a photo, a signature, the Class 10 certificate (for date of birth), a category certificate if applicable, and a PwD certificate if applicable.
- Choose your programme(s) and campus preferences carefully. **Read the 2027-28 Handbook's rules on whether you can apply to both the B.Des and the Integrated Pathway, and how preferences are filled.** [Verify on portal]
- Choose a test city you can reach easily. Prelims is offline.

2.2 DAT Prelims (20 Dec 2026)

Materials usually allowed [REPORTED from past instructions; verify on admit card]: pencils (HB, 2B, 4B, 6B), eraser, sharpener, scale, colour pencils, crayons or oil pastels, sketch pens, and a black pen. Water colours or poster colours have been permitted in some years. **Always follow the admit card.** Blank papers are generally not allowed; you work in the answer booklet.

Two formats to be ready for:

Format A: Handbook scheme	Format B: 2026 actual
Part I: 22 objective (30 marks)	No objective part
Part II: 4 subjective (70 marks)	6 subjective questions, ~14 sub-tasks (100 marks)
Time split: ~25 min Part I, ~150 min Part II	~12 min per sub-task, ~10 min buffer

2.3 DAT Mains: Studio Sensitivity Test

What candidates have reported across years [REPORTED]:

- Make a 3D model from clay, paper, card, thread, wire, foam or found objects on a theme (e.g. "movement", "a creature from your imagination", "a toy for a blind child").
- Sketch an object placed in front of you; observe and draw it from different views.
- Respond to an audio clip or video by drawing or writing.
- Material exploration: "Make as many textures as you can with this paper."
- Group or individual tasks that show the process as well as the result.

What it tests: hand skill, material sensitivity, 3D thinking, originality, and the ability to explain your idea.

2.4 DAT Mains: In-Person Sensitivity Test

- An interaction with a faculty panel. Common themes [REPORTED]:
  - why design
  - observations from your hometown
  - a product you admire and why
  - crafts of your state
  - current design news
  - your hobbies
  - your Studio Test model
- Preparation is covered in Volume 3 §12 and Volume 11.

3. Eligibility, reservation and documents (2027-28)

Requirement	Detail	Status
Education	Class 12, any stream, passed or appearing in 2027	[REPORTED]
Age, General/EWS	born on or after 1 Jul 2006	[REPORTED]
Age, OBC-NCL/SC/ST	on or after 1 Jul 2003	[REPORTED]
Age, PwD	on or after 1 Jul 2001	[REPORTED]
Reservation	As per Govt of India norms (SC 15%, ST 7.5%, OBC-NCL 27%, EWS 10%, PwD 5% horizontal). Some NIDs have state-domicile seats for their home state; check the Handbook for each campus.	[Govt norms; campus domicile REPORTED]
Overseas seats	supernumerary, up to 15%	[OFFICIAL 2026-27]
Fee	₹3,000 (Gen/EWS/OBC) · ₹1,500 (SC/ST)	[REPORTED]

4. Marking and evaluation: what examiners reward

NID has not published a rubric. The criteria below are **[INFERRED]** from NID's stated aims (design aptitude, creativity, visualisation, observation, problem-solving) and from patterns across years.

Criterion	What it looks like on paper	Common way to lose marks
Understanding the question	You answer exactly what is asked: the right number of frames, signboards, the viewpoint	Drawing 3 signboards when 5 are asked; ignoring "write 200 words"
Idea quality / originality	A fresh but sensible interpretation	The first cliché idea (e.g. "save trees" with a crying tree)
Observation	Believable details from real life: the bucket under the tap, the scooter's mirror, slippers outside the door	Generic, empty scenes
Communication	A viewer understands the drawing in about 5 seconds; labels and arrows where they help	Cluttered or ambiguous drawings
Composition	Clear focal point, use of the whole space, varied scale	A tiny drawing in the centre of a huge box
Proportion & perspective	People sized correctly against doors and vehicles; a consistent horizon	Floating people, tilted floors
Empathy / user focus	The solution fits the user (elderly people, children, vendors)	"Cool" ideas that ignore the user
Craft (secondary)	Clean lines, purposeful shading and colour	Over-rendering one corner and leaving the rest unfinished
Completion	Every task attempted	Leaving the last question blank

Photorealism is NOT required. A clear, confident, well-observed sketch with a good idea scores higher than a beautiful drawing of a weak idea. [INFERRED from consistent NID messaging and the nature of the questions]

5. The complete NID DAT syllabus [INFERRED: NID publishes none]

Priority key: **VH** = very high, **H** = high, **M** = medium, **L** = low (for the Dec 2026 Prelims).

A. Design Aptitude (VH)

- **Observation**: noticing details, proportion and context. VH
- **Visual perception**: figure–ground, gestalt (proximity, similarity, closure, continuity), illusions. H
- **Visual reasoning**: reading meaning from images. H
- **Design thinking**: empathise → define → ideate → prototype → test. VH
- **Problem solving**: finding the real problem, constraints, trade-offs. VH
- **Creative thinking**: fluency, flexibility, originality, elaboration. VH
- **Lateral thinking**: unusual viewpoints, reversal, random stimulus. VH
- **Divergent vs convergent thinking**: many ideas, then select one. H
- **Functional thinking**: form follows function; affordances. H
- **User-centred thinking**: personas, accessibility, inclusivity. VH
- **Innovation**: incremental vs radical; frugal design (jugaad, used critically). M
- **Aesthetics**: harmony, proportion, colour, style. H
- **Usability**: learnability, efficiency, error prevention, feedback. H
- **Ergonomics**: anthropometry, reach, posture, grip. M
- **Sustainability**: reduce, reuse, recycle, repair; life-cycle; materials. H

B. Visual Reasoning (H if Part I appears; M otherwise)

- **Patterns, series, figure completion, odd one out, visual analogy**: H
- **Mirror and water images; rotation; reflection**: H
- **Paper folding, cutting and unfolding**: H
- **2D↔3D: cubes, nets, dice, isometric↔orthographic views**: H
- **Spatial relations; hidden and embedded figures; counting figures**: M
- **Perspective, shadows, silhouettes**: H (these also feed drawing)

C. Quantitative Aptitude (L–M)

Basic arithmetic, percentages, ratio, averages, fractions, units, time and distance, area, perimeter, volume, number series, logical puzzles.
How much maths does NID need? Very little. Class 8–10 level is enough. In MCQ years there were usually only 1–4 maths-flavoured items, mostly geometry, area or proportion embedded in a visual context (e.g. "how many tiles cover this floor?"). **Do not** prepare CAT/JEE-level maths. Spend at most 5% of your time here.

D. Logical Reasoning (M)

Sequences, arrangements, analogies, classification, coding-decoding, syllogisms, statement–assumption, cause–effect, visual logic, puzzles.

E. Verbal Ability (L–M)

Vocabulary, comprehension, idioms, interpreting statements, and **descriptive writing** (H for the subjective part).

F. General Awareness, design-focused (M)

Indian crafts and textiles, folk and tribal art, architecture, designers, artists, logos, iconic products, design movements, museums, institutions, awards, UNESCO / GI, sustainability, AI and design.

G. Current Affairs (L for Prelims, M for the interview)

The last 12–18 months of design, architecture, art, tech, AI, environment and culture.

H. Drawing & Visualisation (VH): the core of the paper

Line, shape, form, proportion, perspective (1-, 2- and 3-point), human figures and gestures, memory drawing, scenes, storyboards, product sketching, light and shadow, texture, materials, colour application, lettering.

6. What previous NID papers teach us

6.1 Pattern evolution: older → recent

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2016–2019  ⟶  MCQ-heavy GAT (GK, maths, logic, English, design awareness)
              + 3–5 drawing questions (memory drawing, poster, symbol)
2020–2022  ⟶  Fewer pure-GK MCQs; more visual reasoning & design awareness;
              drawing still ~60–70 marks; "what if" + empathy prompts rise
2023–2025  ⟶  22–27 objective items (30–40 marks), heavily visual (logos,
              spatial, observation); 4 big subjective tasks (60–70 marks)
              Ex (2025): poster from a crow's viewpoint; neem-branch neighbour dispute
2026       ⟶  NO objective part. 6 long subjective questions (~14 tasks):
              empathy sequences (elderly fall), travel kit for grandmother,
              "product you love" + 200 words, Indian drink illustration,
              5 signboards for narrow streets, scene/perspective, redesign
2027       ⟶  [PREDICTION] Subjective-dominant. Objective part may or may
              not return. Everyday India + empathy + communication.
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All year-specific details are [REPORTED] (memory-based). The arrows describe a [TREND-BASED] reading.

6.2 Recurring question types, with an analysis of each

1. Scene drawing with people (markets, stations, homes, festivals)

- *Frequency:* almost every year. [TREND-BASED]
- *How it changed:* "draw a railway platform" has become "draw a three-storey scene", "a narrow street with signboards" or "a view from a specific viewpoint".
- *Skill tested:* perspective, proportion, observation, composition, storytelling.
- *Common misunderstanding:* students think it is about drawing skill alone. It is about **believable life**: activity, interaction, details.
- *How to prepare:* 1 scene a day from observation or memory; learn 1- and 2-point perspective; draw people in 30-second gestures.

2. Sequential drawing / storyboard

- *Frequency:* very frequent, and growing.
- *How it changed:* from neutral processes ("making tea") to empathy and emotion ("helping an elderly person who falls").
- *Skill:* narrative, continuity (same characters and setting across frames), camera angles, emotion.
- *Misunderstanding:* drawing unrelated frames, or changing the character's look between frames.
- *Prepare:* 3/4/6-frame stories twice a week. Vary the shots (wide, medium, close-up).

3. Product redesign / problem-solving

- *Frequency:* very frequent. Examples: the neem branch dispute (2025), a train-related problem (2025), redesigning a product (2026).
- *Skill:* problem identification, user empathy, feasible ideas, explaining with labelled drawings.
- *Misunderstanding:* jumping to a gadget. Examiners want **problem → insight → solution**.
- *Prepare:* the "Problem–User–Constraint–Idea–Sketch" drill (Vol 3 §8).

4. Visual communication: posters, signage, symbols, logos, packaging

- *Frequency:* very frequent. Examples: an orange-juice poster from a crow's viewpoint (2025); 5 signboards for narrow streets (2026).
- *Skill:* hierarchy, colour, typography, simplification, clarity at a distance.

- *Misunderstanding:* adding too much text or detail. Signage must work in 2 seconds.
- *Prepare:* learn pictogram rules (Vol 2A §6) and design 3 posters or symbols a week.

5. Memory drawing + writing

- *Frequency:* frequent. Example: "a product you love + 200 words" (2026).
- *Skill:* recall accuracy, descriptive language, reasoning about design qualities.
- *Prepare:* draw 5 everyday objects from memory each week, then check them against the real thing.

6. Unusual viewpoints / imagination ("what if", "if you were an ant")

- *Frequency:* frequent.
- *Skill:* lateral thinking, scale manipulation, worm's-eye and bird's-eye perspective.
- *Prepare:* the viewpoint drills in Vol 3 §5.

7. Visual reasoning MCQs: folding, cubes, mirror images, counting, patterns

- *Frequency:* every year with Part I (to 2025); absent in 2026.
- *Skill:* spatial visualisation.
- *Prepare:* Vol 4B. Practise until accuracy is above 85%.

8. Logos / design GK MCQs

- *Frequency:* frequent in Part I years (logo identification in 2025).
- *Prepare:* the logo table in Vol 2C and the flashcards in Vol 12.

9. Colour application

- *Frequency:* moderate; often embedded ("use only warm colours", "monochrome").
- *Prepare:* the colour theory section of Vol 2A, plus colouring practice with limited palettes.

10. Creative writing / captions / slogans

- *Frequency:* moderate and rising.
- *Prepare:* timed 150–200-word descriptions; taglines of 3–6 words.

7. Topic frequency & priority table

Frequency is a [TREND-BASED] estimate across roughly 2016–2026 B.Des Prelims from reported memory-based papers. "Expected" is a [PREDICTION] for 20 Dec 2026.

Topic	Frequency	Recent trend	Difficulty	Importance	Expected for DAT 2027
Scene / environment drawing with people	Very high	Rising (multi-level, specific viewpoints)	M–H	Core	**VERY HIGH PRIORITY**
Sequential / storyboard	High	Rising, with an empathy angle	M	Core	**VERY HIGH PRIORITY**
Product redesign / problem-solving	Very high	Rising	M–H	Core	**VERY HIGH PRIORITY**
Poster / signage / pictogram	High	Stable–rising	M	High	**VERY HIGH PRIORITY**
Memory / object drawing	High	Stable	E–M	High	**HIGH PRIORITY**
Descriptive writing (100–200 words)	Medium	Rising	E–M	Medium	**HIGH PRIORITY**

Topic	Frequency	Recent trend	Difficulty	Importance	Expected for DAT 2027
Unusual viewpoint / imagination	Medium–high	Stable	M	High	**HIGH PRIORITY**
Logo / symbol design	Medium	Stable	M	Medium	**HIGH PRIORITY**
Packaging design	Medium	Stable	M	Medium	**MEDIUM PRIORITY**
Colour theory (applied)	Medium	Embedded in drawing	E	Medium	**MEDIUM PRIORITY**
Visual reasoning MCQ (folding, cubes, mirror)	High until 2025	Absent in 2026	M	Conditional	**MEDIUM PRIORITY**
Observation / hidden figures / counting	Medium	Absent in 2026	M	Conditional	**MEDIUM PRIORITY**
Logo identification / brand GK	Medium	Absent in 2026	E	Conditional	**MEDIUM PRIORITY**
Indian crafts / textiles / art GK	Medium	Feeds subjective work	E–M	Medium	**MEDIUM PRIORITY**
Architecture / designers GK	Low–medium	Declining in Prelims	E–M	Interview	**LOW PRIORITY** (Prelims)
Logical reasoning (verbal)	Low–medium	Declining	E–M	Low	**LOW PRIORITY**
Quantitative aptitude	Low	Declining	E	Low	**LOW PRIORITY**
English grammar / vocabulary	Low	Declining	E	Low	**LOW PRIORITY**
Current affairs (design)	Low	Interview-relevant	E	Low (Prelims)	**LOW PRIORITY** (Prelims) / MEDIUM (Mains)
Studio: 3D model / material	Mains every year	Stable	M–H	Mains core	**VERY HIGH PRIORITY** (after Prelims)

8. Exam-day strategy & time management

8.1 Before the exam

- Sleep 7–8 hours. Pack the admit card, photo ID, and a pencil pouch with spares: 2 HB, 2B, 4B, 6B, eraser, kneaded eraser, sharpener, 30 cm scale, 24-shade colour pencils, oil pastels, sketch pens and 2 black fine-liners. Bring a watch if allowed.
- Reach the centre 45 minutes early.

8.2 The first 10 minutes (both formats)

1. Read the **whole paper** once. Circle the counts ("5 signboards", "4 frames", "200 words") and the constraints ("only 3 colours", "bird's-eye view").
2. Write a time budget next to each question (marks ÷ 100 × 165 minutes).
3. Note 2–3 quick idea keywords beside each subjective question. Your brain keeps working on them in the background.

8.3 Time budgets

Format A (22 objective + 4 subjective, 180 min):

Block	Minutes
Read the paper	5

Part I, Q1–22 (30 marks)	25 (skip any item over 90 sec, return later)
Q23 (15)	28
Q24 (20)	38
Q25 (15)	28
Q26 (20)	38
Buffer: finishing, labels, unanswered MCQs	18

Format B (6 questions, ~14 sub-tasks, 100 marks):

- Minutes per sub-task ≈ 165 ÷ number of sub-tasks (≈ 12 min each for 14).
- Use the **70% rule**: once a drawing is 70% done, move on. Come back to polish only if time remains.
- **Never leave a task blank.** A 3-minute rough sketch with labels earns marks; a blank earns zero.

8.4 Guessing policy

No negative marking (officially), so **answer every MCQ**. Eliminate options first, then guess.

8.5 The five golden rules for subjective answers

1. **Answer the question asked**: count, viewpoint, medium, user.
2. **Idea first, rendering second.** Spend 2–3 minutes thinking before drawing.
3. **Fill the box with purpose**: a clear focal point and a sensible scale.
4. **Label smartly**: short labels and arrows for mechanisms and materials. Write a 1–2 line note explaining the idea if allowed.
5. **Finish everything**, then add colour or shading to your strongest piece.

9. How to use this package

Volume	File	Use it when
0	`00-RESEARCH-FINDINGS-AND-EXAM-BLUEPRINT.md`	First, for orientation
1	this file	To understand the exam
2	`02A`, `02B`, `02C` theory notes	Weeks 1–6, daily topic study
3	`03-VOL3-DRAWING-CREATIVE.md`	Every day: drawing drills + 100+ prompts
4	`04A`–`04G` question bank	Daily practice by topic
5	`05-VOL5-EXPECTED-QUESTIONS.md`	Weeks 4+
6–10	model papers 1–5	One per week from week 4 (timed)
11	current affairs	Weekly, plus before the interview
12	revision book + flashcards + top-100 mistakes	Daily 15 min; final week
13	study plans + error log	Day 1, to pick your plan
99	sources + self-audit	Verification

NEXT VOLUME: Volume 2A — Complete Theory Notes: Design Aptitude, Design Fundamentals & Visual Reasoning (`02A-VOL2-THEORY-DESIGN-AND-VISUAL.md`)